Pricing Your Chair

The math stylists avoid — and the price that finally covers it.

A Miko Pierson playbook · Bigger Than Shears™

A full schedule can hide a weak business.

If your prices don't cover your time, your products, and your expenses — or you have to take too many clients just to reach your income goal — you are busy, but you are not profitable. Most service businesses default to two pricing habits: cost-plus guessing, and matching whatever the salon next door charges. Research on how service firms actually price confirms it — most default to cost or competitor-based pricing even when their goals say otherwise. Neither tells you what *your* chair is worth.

Step 1 — Find your real floor

Before you set a price, you need the number it can't go below. Add what every month actually costs you:

- **Booth rent or commission split** — booth rent typically runs $200–$1,500/month; commission splits commonly sit at 40–59% to the salon.
- **Product, back-bar, supplies** — real monthly spend, not a guess.
- **Insurance, license, software, card fees** — small numbers that aren't small.
- **Self-employment tax** — as a 1099 renter you owe the full 15.3%. The safe habit: set aside 25–30% of everything you take.
- **You** — the income your price was supposed to pay.

Divide the total by your real working hours (not booked-chair hours — working ones). That is your floor. Anything priced below it is you paying clients to sit in your chair.

Step 2 — Read what your schedule is telling you

Your booking pattern is pricing data:

- **Booked out two-plus weeks, waitlist forming** → you are underpriced. Demand is telling you.

- **Gaps you can't fill** → a demand problem, not a price problem — lowering the price won't fix visibility.
- **Full but broke** → your floor math (Step 1) has a leak: costs, hours, or price.

Step 3 — Raise it the right way

When the math says raise, raise. The method that keeps clients:

1. **Percentage, not flat.** An 8–20% increase lands cleanly at every service level. A flat $10 is painless on a $150 color and brutal on a $30 trim — flat raises punish your lowest ticket.
2. **Four to six weeks' notice.** Clients who hear it ahead of time feel respected; clients who find out at the register feel ambushed.
3. **Tell them yourself, once, plainly.** Say it while they're in the chair — matter-of-fact, no apology tour: *"Starting March 1, this service goes to $85 — your price stays on the books through February."*
4. **Don't explain your bills.** The price isn't a debate. The salon industry's own guidance — echoed by working salon coaches — reports the same result: a confident, well-noticed raise keeps the overwhelming majority of regulars. The ones who leave over $12 were going to leave eventually.

The number worth knowing

Real payment-processor data puts the average women's cut around $52 in the U.S. — not a target, a sanity check on where the market actually sits. Value-based pricing — pricing what your skill and demand justify, not what the salon across the street charges — is the one pricing orientation researchers have actually linked to better business performance.

A profitable career should pay you well, protect your body, and give you room to breathe. What does your math say your chair is worth?

Sources: Square transaction data via CNN (2024 — avg women's cut $51.71); Mangomint booth-rent vs commission survey; Vagaro booth-rent range + price-raise guidance; Hello Hair Co percentage-raise practice (practitioner); SalonExam self-employment tax guidance (15.3% SE tax); Liozu & Hinterhuber, *Management Decision* 2013 (value-based pricing ↔ performance); Avlonitis & Indounas, *J. Services Marketing* (cost-plus default pattern). Platform figures are vendor-published — directionally consistent, not peer-reviewed.